

9

the am1 post-demo questioning

Listen Before You Answer

the last skills day — and the bit of AM1 you'll be graded on most

Eight days of building. One day of answering. After each of your two AM1 scenario demos, the assessor's pen comes out and the questions start — **around ten of them per demo**, all about what you just did. Each one wants a slightly different shape of answer.

AM2 — the Professional Discussion — has its own format and its own workpacks later. Today is AM1 only.

Today's named device is **Listen → Repeat → Frame → Answer → Check** — five steps for every question. It gives you 2-3 seconds of thinking time that don't look like stalling, and it locks your answer to the question that was actually asked.

Plus the four kinds of question the assessor asks in a demo Q&A, the magic-words versions of "I don't know", and the body language that quietly wins distinctions.

Surely you just... answer the question?

— you, looking at today's agenda

Yes. But which question. In which shape. At which pace.

all teachable. all today.



BRAIN POWER

Think back to a job interview or assessment you've been in. Did you ever give a perfect answer — to a question that hadn't actually been asked? Today fixes that.

turn over — the mocks are tomorrow →

Tomorrow is mock day

You've built the analysis. You've polished the dashboard. You've practised the soft skills. Today is the technique that ties all of it together when the assessor starts asking questions.

FIVE STEPS

1. Listen
2. Repeat
3. Frame
4. Answer
5. Check

2-3 seconds is
not stalling

Priya:

*"You've done the
work. Tomorrow is
about letting them
see it. Good luck."*

Mock Q&A – rehearsal

Assessor:

"Why did you set subscriber_id
to Text rather than Whole Number?"

"So why Text not Whole Number..."

You:

"Because leading zeros are significant.
Whole Number drops them. The merge
would silently lose row 47."

DAY 9

Listen → Repeat → Frame → Answer → Check

Five steps for every assessor question. Sounds mechanical; isn't, once it's in your bones. The whole sequence takes under 30 seconds for most questions, and the first three steps buy you the thinking time the answer needs without making you look like you're stalling.

1. Listen — properly

Let them finish the whole question. The temptation is to start composing your answer mid-sentence — most people do — but the crucial bit usually comes at the end, and missing it means answering a question that wasn't asked. Hold your gaze on the assessor, give a small nod when they finish, and let the silence sit for a beat. The next 2-3 seconds belong to you; using them well is what step 2 is for.

2. Repeat — in your own words

Say the question back, briefly, in your own words. *"So you're asking why I used Left Outer rather than Inner — is that right?"* Three things this does at once: confirms you heard correctly, gives you 2-3 seconds to think, and frames the answer to *their* question instead of yours.

3. Frame — name the shape of the answer

One sentence telling them what kind of answer is coming. *"There are two reasons for that"*, or *"It depends on the context — let me walk through both cases"*, or *"The short answer is X, and I can take you through the reasoning."* This is where you signal you've understood and are about to deliver.

4. Answer — in the shape you just promised

Deliver what you said you would, in the structure you promised. Two reasons? Give two. Walk through? Walk through. Short answer first then reasoning? Short answer, full stop, then reasoning. **Don't drift into related topics.** Answer the question that was asked.

5. Check — invite the follow-up

End with a half-sentence that hands back. *"Does that answer your question?"* or *"Happy to go deeper on any of that"*. Doesn't mean the answer was thin — it means you respect the assessor enough to let them steer.

■ 2-3 seconds of pause is professional. Filler ("um, so, basically...") is not.

Four kinds of question

Assessor questions fall into four categories, each wanting a different shape of answer. Recognise the kind in step 2 of Listen→Repeat→Frame→Answer→Check — that recognition is what shapes the next sentence out of your mouth.

Kind	Sounds like	Wants the shape...
Factual	"What does <code>COUNTIF</code> return?"	A fact, in one sentence. <i>Then stop.</i>
Procedural	"Walk me through how you'd handle a null."	Numbered steps. First X, then Y, if Z then A else B.
Why	"Why did you use Left Outer here?"	Cause → Action → Consequence. Three sentences.
Hypothetical	"What if the data had been twice the size?"	"It depends on... here's the dimension... here's what I'd do."

The next four pages take one kind each, with the answer shape and a worked example.

ASSESSOR FAVOURITE

Saying out loud which kind of question it is — *"that's a why question, so let me walk through cause, action and consequence"* — is unusual and impressive. It signals you've heard the question precisely and know exactly what shape of answer it wants. Don't overdo it (once per Q&A is plenty), but use it at least once.

Factual questions

The simplest kind. They want a piece of information. You either know it or you don't. The single biggest mistake here is **over-answering** — giving a 60-second tour of a related topic when a 10-second fact would have nailed it.

The shape

One sentence with the fact. Optionally one sentence with a brief example. Then stop talking. That's it.

A worked example

Question: "What does COUNTIF return?"

Bad answer (over-answer): "COUNTIF is one of Excel's conditional functions, along with SUMIF and AVERAGEIF, and you use it when you want to count things matching a criterion, for example to count the number of subscribers in Wales, where the criterion would be 'Wales', and you can also use COUNTIFS for multiple conditions..." — at this point the assessor has stopped listening.

Good answer: "COUNTIF returns the count of cells in a range that match a single criterion. For example, `=COUNTIF(tblSubs[region], "Wales")` returns how many subscribers live in Wales." One sentence definition, one sentence example. Stop.



THE SINGLE BIGGEST TELL

The instinct to keep talking comes from anxiety, not from a desire to be helpful. **Long silence after an answer is the assessor thinking, not waiting for more.** Resist the urge to fill it. If the answer was complete, let it sit. They'll come back with another question — or signal they want depth, at which point you go deeper. Don't pre-empt that.

SHOW THIS OFF

After a factual answer, pause for a beat and look at the assessor. If they nod and move on, you nailed it. If they say "and?" or "go on", give them the next layer. Listening for that cue is half the skill.

Procedural questions

The assessor wants to see your *process*, not just the result. They're testing whether you'd handle the situation methodically or improvise it. The shape is **numbered steps**: first X, then Y, if Z then A else B.

The shape

Three or four numbered steps, in order. Each step a short clause. If a decision is involved, name the condition and both branches: "if X, I'd do A; if not, I'd do B."

A worked example

Question: "Walk me through how you'd handle a column with 30% null values."

Answer:

1. **First** — open the column profile bar to confirm exactly what percentage is null and look at the distribution of the non-null values.
2. **Then** — work out what null means in this column. Is it "unknown", "not applicable", or "zero"? That decides everything downstream.
3. **If it represents zero** — Replace Values, null → 0. Document that decision in the methodology note.
4. **If it represents unknown** — decide whether to keep the rows (and report on the populated subset only) or drop them. Depends on whether nulls bias the analysis.
5. **Either way** — add a flag column ("*duration_known*") so downstream filters can include or exclude null rows explicitly.

Five numbered steps, each a short clause, with a clear branch at step 3-4. The assessor can hear the structure.

SHOW THIS OFF

Literally say the words "*first... then... if X... if not X... either way...*" Don't list five things in one paragraph and hope the structure comes through. **Number them out loud.** The assessor can ticking-off your steps mentally as you go.

"Why" questions

You've felt this shape underneath every "say it like this" callout this week — Day 1's Connection Only justification, Day 2's Three Questions Before You Delete, Day 4's defence of every formula. Today it gets named formally: **Cause → Action → Consequence**. Three sentences, every "why" answer.

The three sentences

- **Cause.** The reason. *"Because X."*
- **Action.** What you did about it. *"I did Y."*
- **Consequence.** What would have gone wrong otherwise. *"If I hadn't, Z would have happened."*

The third sentence is the one most candidates skip. It's the one that turns a Pass answer into a Distinction one.

A worked example

Question: *"Why did you set subscriber_id to Text rather than Whole Number?"*

Pass answer (Cause + Action): *"Because leading zeros are significant in subscriber IDs, and Whole Number would drop them. I set it to Text deliberately."*

Distinction answer (Cause + Action + Consequence): *"Because leading zeros are significant in subscriber IDs — 00012 isn't the same as 12. I set the type to Text deliberately. If I'd left it as Whole Number, the merge against viewing_activity would have silently lost row 47 — Isla Hussain, whose ID has a different format — and one whole customer would have disappeared from the churn analysis with no warning."*

ASSESSOR FAVOURITE

Practise every "why" answer with all three sentences. **Cause** ("because X"), **Action** ("I did Y"), **Consequence** ("if I hadn't, Z"). Get it to muscle memory. Most candidates stop at two; the consequence is the gap that wins distinctions.

Hypothetical questions

The hardest kind. The assessor invents a situation that didn't happen, and you have to reason out loud through it. *"What if the data had been twice the size? What if a column had 90% nulls? What if your stakeholder rejected your finding?"* These test your judgement, not your memory.

The shape — three moves

1. **"It depends."** Two words. Buys you thinking time and signals that you understand the situation isn't black-and-white.
2. **"On..."** Name the dimension the answer depends on. *"On whether the nulls are random or concentrated in a particular subgroup."* This is the move that scores. You're showing you can see the analytical structure.
3. **"So if X, then A. If Y, then B."** Walk through the two or three cases. Each case gets a one-sentence treatment.

A worked example

Question: *"What if a column you needed for analysis had 90% null values — would you still use it?"*

Answer: *"It depends — on what the nulls represent and how central the column is to the analysis. If 90% of subscribers have no value because the field is genuinely optional, the column is fine to keep as long as the analysis can handle nulls. If the column is the dependent variable in my analysis — say, the thing I'm trying to predict — 90% missing means I probably can't use it confidently and I'd flag that as a data quality issue before going further. Either way, I'd document the gap in the methodology note so anyone reading the dashboard knows the limitation."*



THE TRAP TO AVOID

Don't pick one scenario and bulldoze through it. *"I'd just drop the column"* is a Fail answer to a hypothetical, because it ignores the dimension the question is asking about. **Always name the dimension first**, then walk through the cases. *"It depends on whether..."* is the way in.

Halfway House

Four sample questions. Match each to a kind and its answer shape. Answers below.

1. "What's the difference between Append and Merge?"

☐ **Factual** ☐ **Procedural** ☐ **Why** ☐ **Hypothetical**

2. "Walk me through how you'd verify a merge didn't drop rows."

☐ **Factual** ☐ **Procedural** ☐ **Why** ☐ **Hypothetical**

3. "Why didn't you just use VLOOKUP?"

☐ **Factual** ☐ **Procedural** ☐ **Why** ☐ **Hypothetical**

4. "What would you do if the cancellations file arrived with a completely different schema next month?"

☐ **Factual** ☐ **Procedural** ☐ **Why** ☐ **Hypothetical**

Answers — check yourself

1. **Factual.** One sentence: "Append stacks rows below; Merge brings columns alongside, matched on a key." Then stop.

2. **Procedural.** Numbered steps: "First, note the row count before the merge. Second, look at the matching-rows indicator in the dialog. Third, after the merge, check the row count again — same number means no drops, more means fan-out."

3. **Why.** Cause→Action→Consequence: "Because next month's data needs to flow through automatically. I used Power Query Merge so it reruns on Refresh. If I'd used VLOOKUP, every month would be half a day of rework."

4. **Hypothetical.** "Depends on which columns changed. A rename means updating references in the Cleaning Sequence. Added or removed columns means re-specifying the merges. Either way, Applied Steps would surface where it broke."

The post-demo Q&A

After each of the two AM1 demos (Data Gathering, Data Analysis), the assessor leads ten minutes of questioning. The format is specific enough to prepare for directly.

What to expect

- **Around 10 questions**, in roughly 10–15 minutes. Some are short (factual); some take a couple of minutes each (procedural or hypothetical).
- **Mix of all four kinds**. Typically 2–3 factual, 3–4 procedural, 2–3 why, 1–2 hypothetical.
- **Tied to specific KSBs**. Each question has a KSB it's testing. The assessor isn't being random — they're working through a checklist.
- **Visible scoring**. The assessor takes notes after each answer. Don't let it throw you. Steady, consistent answers across all 10 score better than three brilliant answers and seven shaky ones.

Pacing across the ten questions

Each answer should take **30 seconds to two minutes**, depending on the kind. If you're consistently under 30 seconds you're probably under-answering. If you're consistently over two minutes you're over-answering and they'll cut you off.

Keep an internal clock. After each answer, take a breath, sip water, and let them ask the next question. The space between questions is yours — don't fill it with extra material from the previous answer.

ASSESSOR FAVOURITE

The strongest candidates **vary their answer length deliberately**. Factual question — 15 seconds. Procedural — a minute. Why — 45 seconds. Hypothetical — 90 seconds. Same candidate; same Q&A; four different paces. The assessor reads that as someone who's listening to *which question* they're being asked, not running a stock script.

"I don't know" — handled well

At some point the assessor will hit something you don't know. The skill is having three reframes of "I don't know" ready, and picking the one that fits.



RED FLAG · THE MAJOR-FAULT ANSWER

"I don't do that" or "I have no evidence" is the *major-fault* answer — the spoken equivalent of a hard fail on a driving test. Not a points deduction; an immediate Refer on the criterion the assessor is asking about. Always reframe: *"I haven't led on that, but I've supported it by..."* or *"I haven't covered it directly, but the principle I'd apply is..."*

The reframe keeps the criterion in play. Bluffing is the second-worst move; saying nothing usable is the worst. Use one of the three magic-words versions below.

Version 1 — "I'm not certain, but my best guess is..."

Use when: you have a partial answer that's probably right. *"I'm not certain, but my best guess is that COUNTA also counts boolean values, since they're stored as text. I'd want to check with a quick test before committing to that."*

This is honest reasoning out loud. The assessor sees the thought process, which is what they're grading anyway. Often scores higher than a confident wrong answer.

Version 2 — "I'd need to check, but the principle would be..."

Use when: you don't know the specific fact but you know how to find out. *"I'd need to check the exact syntax, but the principle would be that XLOOKUP takes the lookup value, the lookup array, and the return array — so the call would look something like that."*

This says "I understand the shape of the answer even if I don't remember the detail." Strong move on factual questions you've forgotten.

Version 3 — "That's outside what I've covered — let me think about it and come back."

Use when: the question is genuinely beyond your scope. *"That's outside what I've covered in this project. Let me think about it for a moment — could we come back to it once I've considered it?"*

The assessor will almost always say yes. You move on; later in the session you bring it back with a considered answer. Way better than guessing in the moment. Even *"I genuinely don't know – could you give me a hint about which direction you're thinking?"* beats a guess.

Body language & pacing

The EPA grades presentation as well as content. Two candidates with identical answers can score differently because of *how* they delivered them. Five practical rules that most candidates ignore.

1. Pause before answering. Properly.

2-3 seconds of silence between the end of their question and the start of your answer is **professional**. It looks like thinking. It reads as confidence. Anyone who jumps in the millisecond the question ends sounds like they're reading from a script — which usually means they're answering a question that wasn't asked.

2. Speak at 75% of your normal pace

Anxiety speeds you up. Counter it deliberately. Slow speech reads as competent; rapid-fire speech reads as nervous. If you can hear yourself slowing down on each answer, you're doing it right.

3. Eye contact, on the assessor, most of the time

Not unbroken — that's creepy. Roughly 70% of the time, looking at them while you speak. Glance away briefly when you're thinking. Look back when you deliver the answer. **Don't look at the laptop screen the whole time** — even if you're walking through a demo. Lift your eyes for the answer itself.

4. Hands on the table or in your lap

Visible, still, not waving. Hands in your pockets reads as defensive; hands gesturing wildly reads as nervous. Hands resting calmly reads as in-control. Practise it.

5. Sip water, on purpose

If you need an extra 5 seconds before answering, reach for the glass of water and take a small sip. Looks natural, reads as composed, and resets your breathing. Have water on the table.

SHOW THIS OFF

None of this is content, all of it is graded. Practise it during your mock. The assessor is watching *how* you answer as much as *what* you answer. Body language and pacing are the two cheapest grade-uplifts in the whole programme.

Say it out loud

Three questions to rehearse. One of each non-factual kind. **Use the full**

Listen→Repeat→Frame→Answer→Check sequence. Say the repeat-back out loud. Pause 2 seconds. Then answer.

Q1 (Procedural) – "Walk me through your Cleaning Sequence."

Numbered. *"Headers and Rename. Trim and Clean. Case. Types – Locale for dates. Empty Cells and Errors. Group By, then Remove Duplicates (find before remove). Conditional Columns. Columns from Examples. Standardise the joining key – the climax."*

Q2 (Why) – "Why Power Query rather than just Excel?"

Cause → Action → Consequence. *"Because next month's data needs to update without rework. I built the pipeline in Power Query so it reruns on Refresh. If I'd done it in Excel formulas, every month would be half a day of repeat work with new bugs likely."*

Q3 (Hypothetical) – "What if your merge produced twice as many rows as expected?"

"It depends" → dimension → cases. *"Depends which side has the duplicate keys. If it's the right-hand table, that's fan-out – I'd de-dupe and re-run. If the duplicates are legitimate, I'd keep them and aggregate in the pivot. Either way the row-count check from Day 3 catches it."*

Q4 (Why) – "Why did you remove the migration-flagged rows?"

Defends a deletion using the **Three Questions Before You Delete**. *"Group By showed 10 subscribers with two rows each, all migration_flag = Y. They were migration artefacts, not legitimate second cancellations. Removing them lost no information; keeping them would have double-counted churn. The deletion was justified."* Three Questions answered = no red flag.



DISTINCTION TELL

Practise the **repeat-back** step out loud – feels artificial at first; natural by the tenth. The 2-3 seconds it buys are the thinking time the answer needs.

Bullet Points — the chapter in 30 seconds

- **Listen → Repeat → Frame → Answer → Check.** Five steps for every assessor question.
- **Four kinds of question**, four answer shapes — recognise the kind first, then pick the shape.
- **Cause → Action → Consequence** on every "why" question. The consequence sentence is what wins distinctions.
- **"It depends" → dimension → cases** on every hypothetical.
- **Three reframes of "I don't know"** — best guess, principle without detail, or "let me think and come back."
- **Pause before answering.** 2-3 seconds of silence reads as professional.
- **Vary your answer length** based on the kind of question. Factual: 15 seconds. Why: 45. Procedural: a minute. Hypothetical: 90.

The Week in Review

Day	Theme	Named device
1	Getting Data In	The Power Query Pipeline
2	Cleaning with Confidence	The Cleaning Sequence • Three Questions Before You Delete
3	The Merge	Append vs Merge • The Six Joins
4	Reading the Data	The Descriptive Five • Validate then Verify • The Two-Route Check
5	Patterns & Relationships	The Three Numbers of a Relationship
6	Pivots and Charts	The Chart Test • Refresh
7	Dashboard Polish	The Polish Pyramid
8	Effective Working Practices	Three Audiences, Three Voices • Headline → Evidence → Caveat
9	Handling the Questioning	Listen → Repeat → Frame → Answer → Check

- ☐ You can recite all nine named devices from memory.
- ☐ You can answer each of the four kinds of question in the right shape, on demand.
- ☐ You can defend every deletion you made with the Three Questions — no unjustified removals.
- ☐ You have one practised version of "I don't know" you can pull out without panic.

that's the programme. you're ready.